Udaipur, Rajasthan

Seven serene lakes so close to the desert and history that's rich with romance, Udaipur is one of India's dreamiest destinations, and especially so in the rainy season, when the peacocks unfurl their plumage in their impressive dance, and the raindrops bedazzle the waters of the lakes like a million minuscule diamantes. The City Palace, perched on the banks of Lake Pichola, is actually a complex of many gorgeous gateways, courtyards and palaces. Check out the Mor Chowk, which has peacocks representing summer, winter and monsoon crafted in three wall niches, each embellished with thousands of pieces of coloured glass.

DO

A boat ride on the lake, cosy under the canopy as the gentle rain splashes in the water around you, will definitely be one of the most memorable moments of your life

EAT

Dal-bati-churma at Krishna Dal Bati Resto. Try *Laal Maas* and other royal Rajasthani fare with lake views at places like Tribute, Jharokha at Karohi Haveli and Ambrai at Amet Haveli

STAY

A plethora of plush five-star properties abound, from the iconic Taj Lake Palace to the sumptuous Oberoi Udaivilas to the relatively new Raffles Udaipur, but there are hotels to suit every budget

GO

Well-connected by air



SHUTTERSTOCK



SHUTTERSTOCK

Araku Valley, Andhra Pradesh

Over the last two decades, the Araku Valley has become famous as the place where India's first 100 per cent organic single-origin coffee is grown. Not only can you enjoy a hot cuppa on a rainy day, you can steep yourself in its history and culture too. The Coffee Museum at Araku takes you on the riveting seed-to-cup journey. Nature lovers will find that the Chaparai or Dumbriguda falls, surrounded by lush forests, are refreshing in summer but spectacular after the monsoon arrives. Araku's Padmapuram Botanical Gardens offer the visitor rare flowers and even rarer 'tree huts'! Climb down about 300 steps to try to spot Golden Geckos in the Borra Caves, which are among India's largest and deepest speleological wonders, filled with interesting formations of stalactites and stalagmites.

DO The Tribal Museum offers a glimpse into the life of the 20 tribes of the Eastern Ghats using life-size tableaux of their daily activities, culinary heritage, and the Dhimsa dance

EAT Bongulo chicken, which is cooked without any water or oil inside bamboo, and *madugula halwa* made of fermented wheat

STAY AP Tourism's Haritha Hill Resort

GO Fly to Visakhapatnam and drive 120 km